GEC1044 Chinese Medicine: Theory and Practice



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GEC1044 Final Project

Improving the physical and mental health of university students

Chinese yam, lotus seed and red date congee

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1 Introduction

Experiencing restricted physical activity made me appreciate how limited energy can complicate everyday tasks. This motivated a recipe for university students that keeps equipment and active preparation manageable. A familiar one-pot congee offers a practical starting point for that aim.

This project addresses fatigue, loss of appetite, unsettled sleep and stress among university students through a Chinese yam, lotus seed and red date congee for home preparation. Irregular meals, academic pressure and limited cooking time make a simple, repeatable recipe relevant to this group. The analysis uses course concepts of pattern differentiation, food properties and ingredient combination to explain the design, while a brief psychological perspective considers its place in student routines.[1]

My photograph of a pulse diagnosis slide at Thong Chai connects this concern with Lecture 7's emphasis on combining observations and history (Figure 1).[2] A single symptom starts an inquiry; the whole presentation guides the response.

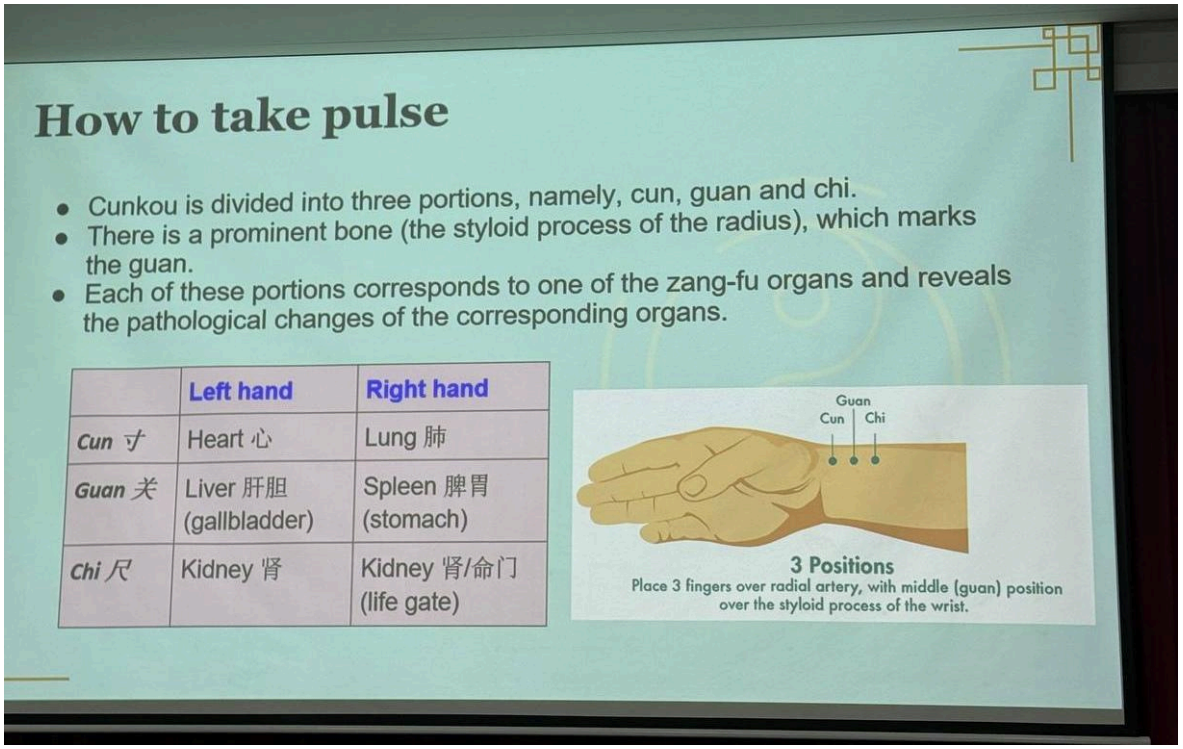


Figure 1 Pulse positions explained during the Thong Chai teaching session. Photograph by the author.[3]

2 Understanding the health concerns

2.1 A Chinese medicine perspective

The recipe needs a more specific basis than the idea that tired students need nourishing food. Lecture 7 distinguishes a symptom from a pattern, or zheng: the same complaint can occur in different combinations of signs. The four diagnostic methods establish that combination before

[1] National University of Singapore, GEC1044, "Assessment," course page text saved November 5, 2026; GEC1044, Lecture 9, "Food Therapy Living in Harmony with Nature," 2:12–3:24 and 38:51.

[2] GEC1044, Lecture 7, "The Art and Science of TCM Diagnostics," Part One, 10:00–12:22.

[3] Lou Yu, photograph of the pulse diagnosis teaching slide, Thong Chai visit collection, October 15, 2026, photo_2026-10-15_23-47-39.jpg.

a treatment principle is chosen.[4] Here I use possible patterns to explain the recipe's design, rather than diagnose my earlier movement difficulties.

Fatigue together with poor appetite suggests investigating Spleen qi deficiency. Within Chinese medicine, the Spleen and Stomach receive and transform food; reduced nourishment gives a traditional explanation for linking eating poorly with low energy.[5] Inquiry would therefore cover meal regularity, stool consistency and whether tiredness persists after rest. The practitioner would also examine the tongue and pulse. Sleep disturbance alone would not establish this digestive pattern.

If poor appetite and fatigue accompany easily interrupted sleep, palpitations and a pale complexion, the question becomes whether Heart and Spleen deficiency gives a better account. A Chinese University of Hong Kong booklet describes this combination with loose stools and a pale tongue with a thin white coating. I use its description of the pattern, which appears in a booklet for young cancer survivors, without applying that population's treatment plan to students.[6] The Heart's association with shen, or mental and emotional activity, explains why this line of reasoning includes sleep as well as digestion.

Academic stress also belongs in this pattern discussion. Lecture 10 distinguishes normal emotions from prolonged or excessive emotional activity within the Chinese medical framework. In the HKU School of Chinese Medicine account, excessive brooding can constrain qi and impair the Spleen's transformation of food, linking reduced appetite and bloating with diminished nourishment and energy (蔡顥輝, 2017). In a student scenario, sustained worry about deadlines could therefore prompt inquiry into both eating and sleep. Read alongside the Heart-Spleen pattern above, this offers a traditional rationale for considering digestion and mental rest together; it is not a biomedical explanation of stress.

This link supports the congee's chosen direction when worry accompanies signs of deficiency, but it does not make stress itself a diagnosis. The ingredients are selected for their traditional digestive and nourishing roles, rather than as a general treatment for academic pressure. Persistent emotional distress requires assessment beyond a household recipe.

The corresponding food therapy principle is to support the Spleen and nourishment while including ingredients traditionally used to calm shen. Yam and rice establish the digestive focus; lotus seeds connect that focus with calming shen; dates add a small nourishing component. This chain makes the ingredient choice answer the proposed pattern. The Department of Health also lists rice, yam and dates in dietary guidance for qi deficiency constitution, a broader category than a current clinical pattern.[7]

Alternative signs change the direction. Hong Kong University's discussion links Liver fire insomnia with irritability and phlegm heat with gastric bloating, a heavy head and a bitter taste.[8] Such a presentation needs a different assessment and principle, rather than simply more tonic ingredients. Lecture 9 makes the same point through a cooling heat-dampness

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[4] GEC1044, Lecture 7, Part One, 3:23–4:32 and 10:00–12:22; Part Two, 13:22–19:17.

[5] GEC1044, Lecture 2, “Natural Philosophy Organs and Meridians,” section on zang-fu; Lecture 9, 38:51.

[6] Chinese University of Hong Kong, School of Chinese Medicine et al., 中醫藥與青少年和青年癌症康復者小冊子, series 1, 睡眠困難, 9, accessed November 6, 2026, https://scm.cuhk.edu.hk/images/2024/7-6/_01-Booklet__.pdf. Used here for its description of the Heart-Spleen deficiency pattern.

[7] Hong Kong Department of Health, Chinese Medicine Regulatory Office, “中醫體質分類與養生,” “氣虛體質,” accessed November 6, 2026, https://www.cmro.gov.hk/html/b5/useful_information/public_health/exhibit_boards/Body_Constitution_and_Relevant_Health_Maintenance.html.

[8] 梁頌然, “中醫藥如何治療失眠,” University of Hong Kong Faculty of Medicine, February 5, 2022, https://www.med.hku.hk/zh-hk/media/knowledge-exchange/newspaper-columns/2022/feb/chinese-medicine-treatment-for-insomnia.

soup described as unsuitable for a weak Spleen and Stomach. The present congee is therefore a focused nourishing option within the traditional framework, not a general insomnia remedy.[9]

2.2 Individualized care: a parallel from acupuncture

Lecture 8's distinction between reinforcing deficiency and reducing excess illustrates why an intervention must follow assessment rather than a symptom label. My Thong Chai photograph records the acupuncture teaching context (Figure 2); the comparison with food therapy concerns this reasoning principle, not a claim that the two interventions have the same effects. For this congee, a possible Spleen qi or Heart-Spleen deficiency pattern explains the nourishing direction. Liver fire or phlegm heat presentations require a different assessment, so ingredients should not be added simply because a student reports insomnia.



Figure 2 Acupuncture teaching at Thong Chai. Photograph by the author; the slide records precautions, while the comparison of treatment principles draws on Lecture 8.

2.3 Psychology and recipe usability

Academic pressure can create a reinforcing cycle: repeated worry interrupts sleep, fatigue makes studying harder, and reduced progress adds further pressure. Irregular meals or reduced appetite can make daily care harder still. This psychological account can be read alongside the traditional discussion of excessive brooding and the Spleen, while keeping their different explanatory frameworks distinct.

Behavioural activation emphasizes manageable activities that offer a sense of achievement (Cacioppo, Freberg and Cacioppo, 2022). This informs the recipe's one-pot method and two-portion batch: completing a simple meal may provide a small, achievable task and help establish a regular eating routine. The long simmer remains a constraint, so preparation is better planned for a less pressured period. These are reasons for the design's usability, not measured psychological benefits from eating the congee.

[9] GEC1044, Lecture 9, 7:03, 38:51 and 44:57.

3 The recipe and its ingredients

3.1 Chinese yam lotus seed and red date congee

I designed the congee around a simple aim: make a nourishing meal that is easy to prepare, with a traditional rationale linking digestion and mental rest. The starting point is the Hong Kong Department of Health's yam and red date congee. Its published example uses 200 g yam and 30 g red dates with rice. My version adds lotus seeds, uses 15 g red dates for a lighter sweetness, and specifies the rice and water so that the cooking process can be repeated.[10]

The proposed batch makes two portions. All quantities below are planned kitchen weights. Fresh yam and dried ingredients are listed separately because their weights and preparation differ.

The 20 g lotus seeds give 10 g of dried seeds per intended portion. This makes them a supporting ingredient alongside 100 g fresh yam, rather than the main bulk of the meal. Their traditional digestive and calming functions explain their inclusion; the exact weight is a kitchen design choice for this first version. The 15 g dates give 7.5 g per portion, half the Department of Health example's batch quantity. This keeps dates subordinate to yam and reduces the amount of dried fruit while retaining some sweetness. These food weights do not establish a therapeutic dose or a measured effect on sleep.

Ingredient	Planned weight	Specification
Chinese yam	200 g	Fresh peeled edible portion
Lotus seeds	20 g	Dried shelled seeds with green embryos removed
Red dates	15 g	Dried pitted edible portion
Rice	80 g	Dry uncooked white rice
Water	1,000 ml	Starting amount; add if needed during cooking

3.2 Why these ingredients belong together

Chinese yam, or shan yao, anchors the digestive aim. The Polytechnic University describes dried yam rhizome as sweet and neutral, associated with the Spleen, Lung and Kidney, and traditionally used to support the Spleen and Stomach. This recipe uses fresh yam, following the Department of Health's congee preparation.[11] Soft cooked yam also makes the meal more substantial than a herbal drink.

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[10] Hong Kong Department of Health, Chinese Medicine Regulatory Office, “药补或食补?” accessed November 6, 2026, https://www.cmro.gov.hk/html/gb/useful_information/public_health/exhibit_boards/Herbal_Tonics_or_Food_Tonics.html. Rice, lotus seeds, water, portions and the reduced date quantity are this project's adaptation.

[11] Hong Kong Polytechnic University, “山药,” accessed November 6, 2026, https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/sc/herbal/common-yam-rhizome; Hong Kong Department of Health, “药补或食补?”

Lotus seed, or lian zi, connects digestive support with calming shen. Its sweet, astringent and neutral description and affinities to the Spleen, Kidney and Heart explain its supporting role.[12] I specify dried shelled seeds with the green embryo removed, distinguishing the ingredient from lotus plumule.

Red dates, or da zao, contribute sweetness and traditional nourishment. Their listed functions include supplementing middle qi and nourishing blood and calming shen; they are sweet and warm, associated with the Spleen and Stomach.[13] The smaller quantity keeps this supporting role clear. No extra sugar is included.

Rice supplies the starch that thickens the congee and gives it a familiar meal base. Lecture 9 also includes rice among sweet foods associated with nourishment.[14] Its kitchen function therefore supports the same overall choice.

Ingredient	Nature and flavour	Traditional affinity	Role in this congee
Chinese yam	Neutral and sweet	Spleen Lung Kidney	Main digestive and nourishing focus
Lotus seed	Neutral sweet and astringent	Spleen Kidney Heart	Links digestive support with calming shen
Red date	Warm and sweet	Spleen Stomach	Supporting nourishment and natural sweetness
Rice	Sweet in the lecture classification	Food base	Provides a familiar meal and soft texture

My Thong Chai photograph shows the framework applied here (Figure 3): nature, flavour, meridian affinity and function are separate questions about each ingredient.[15]

[12] Hong Kong Polytechnic University, “莲子,” accessed November 6, 2026, https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/sc/herbal/lotus-seed.

[13] Hong Kong Polytechnic University, “大枣,” accessed November 6, 2026, https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/sc/herbal/chinese-date.

[14] GEC1044, Lecture 9, 22:51.

[15] GEC1044, Lecture 9, 7:03, 38:51 and 44:57.

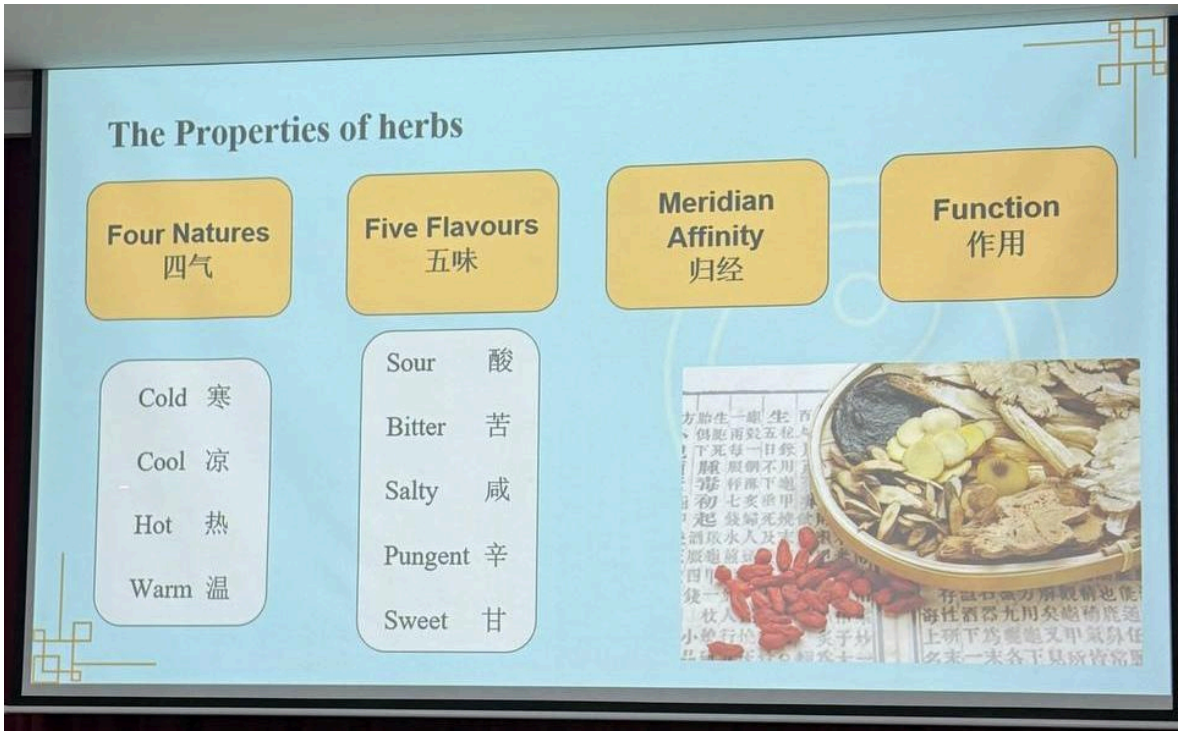


Figure 3 A teaching slide on the properties of herbs at Thong Chai. Photograph by the author.[16]

3.3 Suitability and the choices behind the combination

Lecture 9's chief, minister, assistant and envoy scheme helped me rank the ingredients. Yam anchors the main aim and lotus seeds support it while adding the traditional shen connection. Dates contribute a smaller nourishing component, and rice makes the combination a meal. A simple household recipe does not need an extra herb to fill every formula role.[17]

This restraint follows the course's account of the Zhang Zhongjing tradition: the patient's presentation guides formula selection.[18] Adding ginseng or several more tonics would need a further reason. The proposed combination already addresses its chosen direction, and more ingredients would add cost and preparation without resolving a new finding.

4 Home preparation and practical evaluation

4.1 Preparation method

For this recipe, use a saucepan with a lid, a kitchen scale and a measuring jug. Weigh the edible portions listed above. Rinse the lotus seeds and follow the packet's soaking instructions, checking that the green embryos have been removed. Wash the rice. Peel the yam with gloves if its sap irritates the skin, then cut it into small pieces. Wash and pit the dates.

Place the rice, lotus seeds and 1,000 ml water in the saucepan. Bring to the boil, then reduce the heat to a gentle simmer. Add the yam and dates and cook until the rice breaks down and the lotus seeds are tender. Stir occasionally and add water if needed. Allow about 45 to 60

[16] Lou Yu, photograph of “The Properties of Herbs” slide, Thong Chai visit collection, October 15, 2026, photo_2026-10-15_23-47-48.jpg.

[17] GEC1044, Lecture 9, 54:45.

[18] GEC1044, Lecture 3, section on formula medicine and the tradition attributed to Zhang Ji or Zhang Zhongjing.

minutes of cooking, in addition to ingredient preparation and any soaking. Tenderness is the final check. Divide into two portions and serve warm.

A one-pot method reduces equipment and washing up, but an hour of cooking still requires planning. This is more realistic for a planned evening or weekend meal than for a rushed morning. Preparing two portions together can spread that work across two meals, or allow two people to share the batch. If saving a portion, cool it quickly, ideally within one hour, refrigerate, and use within 24 hours; reheat only once until steaming hot throughout, following Food Standards Agency advice for cooked rice.[19]

4.2 Serving and everyday use

Serve one portion as part of a regular meal rather than skipping food during a busy study period. Lecture 10's yangsheng framework places diet alongside rest, movement and emotional cultivation. Applied here, a planned mealtime, a regular sleep schedule and manageable activity such as a gentle campus walk provide a practical setting for the recipe. Drinking water regularly can accompany the meal; warm water is an option according to comfort and preference. Neither water temperature nor combining these routines has been shown here to increase the congee's effects.

4.3 Intended users and suitability

The design is for students with fatigue and poor appetite whose wider presentation could fit Spleen qi deficiency, or Heart-Spleen deficiency when sleep concerns are also present. It is not a general recommendation for all tired or stressed students. Prominent heat or phlegm signs require a different assessment. Use food-grade ingredients and account for allergies, prescribed diets and individual tolerance. Persistent fatigue, appetite loss, sleep problems or emotional distress require appropriate professional assessment; this meal does not replace treatment.

4.4 Cooking record (pending trial)

The congee has not yet been prepared, so this draft cannot report observed results. The required practical component remains incomplete. Complete the following record from an actual cooking trial before submission; the cover photograph and Thong Chai teaching photographs do not document this recipe's preparation.

Trial date: [to complete].

Actual edible weights: yam [ ] g; dried lotus seeds [ ] g; pitted dates [ ] g; dry rice [ ] g.

Water: starting [ ] ml; additional [ ] ml.

Timing: lotus seed soaking [ ]; active preparation [ ] minutes; simmering [ ] minutes.

Yield: [ ] g or ml; portions obtained [ ].

Cost: total ingredients S$[ ]; per portion S$[ ].

Record whether the yam and lotus seeds are tender, whether the rice has broken down, and whether the thickness and sweetness are acceptable. Note any sticking, extra water or longer

[19] Food Standards Agency, “Home Food Fact Checker,” section on rice, accessed November 6, 2026, https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/home-food-fact-checker/home-food-fact-checker.

cooking needed. Explain one change for a second trial using these observations. Taste and cooking convenience can be evaluated here; a single meal cannot establish an improvement in a clinical condition.

4.5 Preparation photographs (pending trial)

[Insert own process photograph A: ingredients on the scale. Caption: date, ingredient identities and actual edible weights.]

[Insert own process photograph B: prepared ingredients before cooking. Caption: soaked lotus seeds with green embryos removed, peeled yam and pitted dates.]

[Insert own process photograph C: congee during simmering. Caption: elapsed time and any additional water or adjustments.]

[Insert own process photograph D: finished congee divided into portions. Caption: final cooking time, actual yield and observed texture.]

5 Reflection and conclusion

The strength of this recipe is its connection between student concerns, a possible pattern and specific ingredient roles. Fatigue and poor appetite give the yam-and-rice base a clear digestive focus. Where a Heart-Spleen deficiency pattern is considered, lotus seeds and a small amount of dates extend that rationale to calming shen. Academic worry helps explain why digestion and sleep should be considered together, but stress alone does not establish a pattern. Heat-related sleep disturbance would call for a different assessment.

The main practical limitation is time: one saucepan reduces equipment, but soaking and simmering still require planning. Preparing two portions may make the work more manageable. The cooking trial must test whether the proposed weights, water and timing produce tender ingredients, acceptable sweetness and a usable portion at a reasonable cost. Until that trial and its photographs are added, practical feasibility remains a design claim rather than a demonstrated result.

This project therefore addresses the physical and mental health of university students through a focused food therapy design. Its intended contribution is a manageable meal supported by course-based reasoning, not evidence of a treatment for fatigue, insomnia or stress. The next step is to prepare the congee, document the process and revise the recipe in light of the actual result.

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